

Scott Kellum

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To the hiring committee

Thank you for the opportunity to apply for the Director of Product Design role at Thistle. With 20 years of experience leading design teams and creating scalable product experiences, I am excited to bring my proven track record of building high-performing design organizations and delivering exceptional user experiences to your team.

My experience at Mariana Tek exemplifies exactly the type of player/coach leadership this role requires. As Lead Product Designer, I took on the dual responsibility of directly executing complex design projects while simultaneously building the design culture and systems that would scale the organization. I led design on client-side products in a complex B2B environment, coordinating seamlessly with sales, research, product, and development teams—the same cross-functional collaboration essential to this role.

What made my work at Mariana Tek particularly impactful was my ability to think holistically about complex systems while maintaining focus on user needs and business objectives. The platform served diverse stakeholders—from studio owners managing their businesses to end consumers booking fitness classes—requiring me to empathize with multiple user types and create compelling experiences for each. This user-centered approach, combined with deep business understanding, allowed me to resolve ambiguity and build consensus across teams with competing priorities.

The results speak to the effectiveness of this approach: I increased the product team's velocity by 3x through the creation and implementation of a comprehensive design system. This wasn't just about efficiency—it created a positive feedback loop between sales and product that fueled the company's growth from a national to global business. The scalable design solutions I advocated for became the foundation that supported Mariana Tek's expansion and eventual successful acquisition by Xplor.

My experience developing and iterating on design systems aligns perfectly with your need for “repeatable systems and guides that help design scale across the organization.” At Mariana Tek, I didn't just create design components—I built the processes, documentation, and design specifications that enabled consistent, high-quality experiences across all touchpoints. I regularly presented design concepts to diverse stakeholders, articulated design requirements with product managers and engineers, and negotiated solutions that balanced user needs with technical constraints and business goals.

I'm particularly excited about the opportunity to partner with your product team on research initiatives that inform both design direction and business strategy. My experience leveraging data-informed design decisions, combined with my deep understanding of user research and industry best practices, positions me to drive meaningful insights that shape product development.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my proven ability to scale design organizations, create compelling user experiences, and drive measurable business outcomes can contribute to Thistle's continued success.

Warm regards,
Scott Kellum